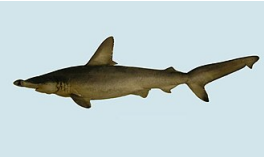
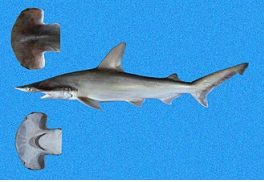


	Species	Common names	IUCN Red List status	Population trend	References
	<i>Eusphyr a blochii</i>	<u>Winghead shark</u>	EN Endangered	Decreasing	^[24]
	<i>Sphyr a alleni</i>	<u>Shovelbill shark</u>	NE Not Evaluated	Unknown	^[25]
	<i>Sphyr a corona</i>	<u>Scalloped bonnethead</u>	CR Critically Endangered	Decreasing	^[26]
	<i>Sphyr a gilberti</i>	<u>Carolina hammerhead</u>	DD Data Deficient	Unknown	^[27]
	<i>Sphyr a lewini</i>	<u>Scalloped hammerhead</u>	CR Critically Endangered	Decreasing	^[28]
	<i>Sphyr a media</i>	<u>Scoophead</u>	CR Critically Endangered	Decreasing	^[29]
	<i>Sphyr a mokarran</i>	<u>Great hammerhead</u>	CR Critically Endangered	Decreasing	^[30]
	<i>Sphyr a tiburo</i>	<u>Bonnethead</u>	EN Endangered	Decreasing	^[31]
	<i>Sphyr a tudes</i>	<u>Smalleye hammerhead</u>	CR Critically Endangered	Decreasing	^[32]
	<i>Sphyr a zygaena</i>	<u>Smooth hammerhead</u>	VU Vulnerable	Decreasing	^[33]

Relationship with humans

According to the International Shark Attack File, humans have been subjects of 17 documented, unprovoked attacks by hammerhead sharks within the genus *Sphyrna* since AD 1580. No human fatalities have been recorded.^[34] Most hammerhead shark species are too small to inflict serious damage to humans.^[8]

The great and the scalloped hammerheads are listed on the World Conservation Union's (IUCN) 2008 Red List as endangered, whereas the smalleye hammerhead is listed as vulnerable. The status given to these sharks is as a result of overfishing and demand for their fins, an expensive delicacy. Among others, scientists expressed their concern about the plight of the scalloped hammerhead at the American Association for the Advancement of Science annual meeting in Boston. The young swim mostly in shallow waters along shores all over the world to avoid predators.^[35]

Shark fins are prized as a delicacy in certain countries in Asia (such as China), and overfishing is putting many hammerhead sharks at risk of extinction. Fishermen who harvest the animals typically cut off the fins and toss the remainder of the fish, which is often still alive, back into the sea.^[36] This practice, known as finning, is lethal to the shark.^[37]

In captivity

The relatively small bonnethead is regular at public aquariums, as it has proven easier to keep in captivity than the larger hammerhead species,^{[38][39]} and it has been bred at a handful of facilities.^[40] Nevertheless, at up to 1.5 m (5 ft) in length and with highly specialized requirements, very few private aquarists have the experience and resources necessary to maintain a bonnethead in captivity.^[41] The larger hammerhead species can reach more than twice that size and are considered difficult, even compared to most other similar-sized sharks (such as *Carcharhinus* species, lemon shark, and sand tiger shark) regularly kept by public aquariums.^[39] They are particularly vulnerable during transport between facilities, may rub on surfaces in tanks, and may collide with rocks, causing injuries to their heads, so they require very large, specially adapted tanks.^{[39][42]} As a consequence, relatively few public aquaria have kept them for long periods.^[39] The scalloped hammerhead is the most frequently maintained large species, and it has been kept long term at public aquaria in most continents, but primarily in North America, Europe, and Asia.^{[39][43][44]} In 2014, fewer than 15 public aquaria in the world kept scalloped hammerheads.^[42] Great hammerheads have been kept at a few facilities in North America, including Atlantis Paradise Island Resort (Bahamas), Adventure Aquarium (New Jersey), Georgia Aquarium (Atlanta), Mote Marine Laboratory (Florida), and the Shark Reef at Mandalay Bay (Las Vegas).^[45] Smooth hammerheads have also been kept in the past.^[39]

Protection

Humans are the main threat to hammerhead sharks. Although they are not usually the primary target, hammerhead sharks are caught in fisheries all over the world.^[46] Tropical fisheries are the most common place for hammerheads to be caught because of their preference to reside in warm waters.^[46] The total number of hammerheads caught in fisheries is recorded in the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations Global Capture Production dataset.^[46] The number steadily increased from 75 metric tons in 1990, to 6,313 metric tons by 2010.^[46]

Shark fin traders say that hammerheads have some of the best quality fin needles which makes them good to eat when prepared properly.^[46] Hong Kong is the world's largest fin trade market and accounts for about 1.5% of the total annual amount of fins traded.^[46] It is estimated that around 375,000 great hammerhead sharks alone are traded per year which is equivalent to 21,000 metric tons of biomass.^[46] However, most sharks that are caught are only used for their fins and then discarded.^[46] The actual meat of hammerheads is generally unwanted. Consumption of regular hammerhead meat has been recorded in countries such as Trinidad and Tobago, Venezuela, Kenya, and Japan.^[46]

In March 2013, three endangered, commercially valuable sharks, the hammerheads, the oceanic whitetip, and porbeagle, were added to Appendix II of CITES, bringing shark fishing and commerce of these species under licensing and regulation.^[47]

Cultural significance

Among Torres Strait Islanders, the hammerhead shark, known as the *beizam*, is a common family totem and often represented in cultural artefacts such as the elaborate headdresses worn for ceremonial dances, known as dhari (dari). They are associated with law and order.^[48] Renowned artist Ken Thaiday Snr is known for his representations of *beizam* in his sculptural *dari* and other works.^{[49][50]}

In native Hawaiian culture, sharks are considered to be gods of the sea, protectors of humans, and cleaners of excessive ocean life. Some of these sharks are believed to be family members who died and have been reincarnated into shark form, but others are considered man-eaters, also known as *niuhi*. These sharks include great white sharks, tiger sharks, and bull sharks. The hammerhead shark, also known as *mano kihikihi*, is not considered a man-eater or *niuhi*; it is considered to be one of the most respected sharks of the ocean, an *aumakua*. Many Hawaiian families believe that they have an *aumakua* watching over them and protecting them from the *niuhi*. The hammerhead shark is thought to be the birth animal of some children. Hawaiian children who are born with the hammerhead shark as an animal sign are believed to be warriors and are meant to sail the oceans. Hammerhead sharks rarely pass through the waters of Maui, but many Maui natives believe that their swimming by is a sign that the gods are watching over the families, and the oceans are clean and balanced.^[51]

See also

- List of hammerhead sharks
- List of prehistoric cartilaginous fish

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A hammerhead shark in shallow water



Man carrying a hammerhead shark along a street in Mogadishu, Somalia



Scalloped hammerhead swimming



Most, if not all, hammerhead shark species are threatened with extinction.



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